



Electronic monitoring for medical and health

In business. Video surveillance and business security systems are now used for everything from measuring efficiency to data security, and to compliance with securities laws. Businesses use video surveillance systems for a lot more than catching shoplifters or reducing the time employees spend goofing off. Employee monitoring is being used to increase customer satisfaction, improve employee performance and enhance productivity.

Employers justify monitoring of their employee activities as essential to protect the organisation from unwanted actions conducted over its network. The responsibility to secure the network outweighs employees' expectations for privacy in the workplace. Balancing employee privacy and business needs is essential for developing an effective and defensible monitoring programme. While it is recognised that abuses may occur, these can be avoided by a participatory introduction of the new technology, allowing the workers some input into the design and implementation of the monitoring systems.

Medical and health use. At present, almost all the hospital activities are electronically monitored. Continuous electronic monitoring could save hospitals billions of rupees. Elderly people in care homes can be tagged with electronic monitors used to keep track of young offenders. Electronic monitoring can also be used to prevent dementia pa-

tients from wandering away. Use of electronic monitoring devices for inhalers is growing rapidly because of their ability to provide objective and detailed adherence data to support clinical decision making.

For animals. As mentioned earlier, GPS collars and electronic tags are being used to monitor animal behaviour in an environment, and track and study migration patterns, respectively.

For criminals. Electronic tagging is commonly used for people who have been sentenced to electronic monitoring by a court, or are required to wear a tag upon release from prison. With overcrowded jails and the high cost of incarceration, many states have turned to electronic monitors as a cost-effective way to send people home and free up jail space.

Electronic tagging is also used in immigration contexts in some jurisdictions. If the device is based on GPS technology, it is usually attached to a person by a probation officer, law enforcement or a private monitoring services company field officer, and is capable of tracking the wearer's location wherever the satellite signal is available.

Electronic monitoring tags can also be used in combination with curfews to confine defendants or offenders to their homes as a condition of bail, as a standalone order or as a form of early release from prison. The combination of electronic monitoring with a curfew usually relies on RFID technology, which differs from GPS technology.

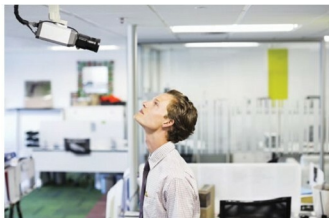
While the role of electronic monitoring

in community corrections and the overall criminal-justice system is still insignificant, the technology has improved (especially with regard to GPS) and become an increasingly used criminal-justice tool. Using tracking systems, criminal justice agencies can monitor an individual's location and be alerted to any unauthorised movements. Thus these systems can be useful in detention, restriction and surveillance.

Potential benefits of electronic tagging are cost savings to the criminal justice system and more optimal use of prison space. However, constant surveillance of people, particularly through the use of devices affixed to their body or implanted beneath the skin, raises serious civil liberty and ethical concerns.

For job performance. Productivity issues and misuse of the Internet during office hours are the main reasons why employers resort to monitoring their staff's online behaviour at work. Various studies conducted by psychological scientists have found that electronic monitoring is, in fact, associated with higher performance; not only that, the more frequently the workers were monitored, the better they performed.

In an effort to enhance employee performance, organisations like call centres are increasingly using electronic technology to monitor their workers on the job. With electronic performance monitoring, supervisors



Electronic monitoring for job performance